1.6 The Peacock and the Crane

There was once a very conceited Peacock who had a gorgeous tail like no other bird. So, when he met a Crane one day, the Peacock scoffed at the Crane's colourless and dull feathers, and immediately spread his own colourful tail for the Crane to see and admire.

"Look at my feathers," he boasted, "how they shine in all the colours of the rainbow, while yours are so pale! I am dressed like a king!"

"That's true," the Crane answered, "but I can fly high above, among the clouds and the stars and I can see all the beauty of the earth in all its glory, while you live down here just like any other cock."

Fine feathers don't make fine birds.

- **conceited :** very proud, vain, arrogant
- **gorgeous :** beautiful, magnificent, stunning
- **scoffed at :** laughed at (the crane) rudely and scornfully
- **Fine feathers don't make fine birds :** The saying 'Fine feathers make fine birds!' is used in a negative sense, to indicate that looks or flashy clothes may not be very important after all.

POINTERS

1. Read the following sentences carefully and choose the correct meaning.

   (a) The Peacock had a gorgeous tail like no other bird.

   - ☐ No other bird had a tail.
   - ☐ The Peacock's tail was more beautiful than any other bird's.
   - ☐ All birds had gorgeous tails.

   (b) Fine feathers don't make fine birds.

   - ☐ You cannot use feathers to make birds.
   - ☐ You can judge something by its outward beauty.
   - ☐ Something that looks beautiful may not really be useful.

2. Read the story aloud (or present it) in groups of three – the narrator, the peacock and the crane.
3. Imagine you are the Crane. What actions and words of the Peacock would you not like? Write about it in short.
4. Discuss what a friendly and good-natured peacock would say to a crane. Write his speech. (5-8 lines.)
5. Find one more example which shows that a beautiful appearance is not enough.
6. List 5 adjectives and 5 nouns from the story.
7. Find five adjectives that end with (a) '–ful' and (b) '–less'. Then write the antonym of each.
8. Start a collection of proverbs. A proverb is a short, well-known sentence or phrase that gives advice or tells you what is generally true. For example, 'A stitch in time saves nine' means 'If one does something in time or immediately, it saves a lot of work later'. A proverb is also known as a saying. Here are some proverbs for your collection.

   - Appearances can be deceptive.
   - Do not judge by appearance; a rich heart may be under a poor coat.
   - All that glitters is not gold.
   - You can't tell a book by its cover.
   - Clothes do not make the man.

9. Visit a library : This story is a fable. Find two more fables. Share them with your friends.